FT FollowThrough

The Handyman Playbook

What to say from the first call to the five-star review. Copy the lines, put them in your own words, and keep this on your phone.

1. The first call or message

Sound calm, understand the job, and book a next step. Ask:

- What's on your list? Send me everything, even the small things.
- Is anything leaking, loose or unsafe? I'll put that first.
- Do you have the parts, or should I bring them?
- Can you send photos of each item?

> "Thanks for calling [Business], this is [Name]. Tell me what's on your list and I'll see how we can help."

> "Text me photos of each item and I'll send a price for the whole list. I can come Tuesday morning or Thursday afternoon. Which works better?"

2. Presenting the quote

- Quote the whole list as one flat price, with a price for each item so they can drop some.
- Say what's included in materials, and what happens if you find more behind the wall.
- Mention your minimum charge and why: the best value is several jobs in one visit.
- Send it in writing the same day, and say how long it holds.

> "Here's the list, here's the price for each item, and here's the total. I can do all of it on [day]. Anything you'd like to add or drop?"

3. The 7 objections handymen hear and what to say

Acknowledge it, ask a question, answer honestly, suggest a next step.

1. "The guy on Nextdoor charges less."
"That's fair, there's always someone cheaper. Does he carry insurance and come back if something isn't right? I do both, and I show up when I say I will. Want me to send proof of insurance with the quote?"

2. "I'll get a couple more quotes."
"Sure. Are you comparing by the hour or for the whole list? Check whether each price covers the full list, what's included in materials, and whether they're insured. I'll text you Wednesday in case questions come up."

3. "Can you just charge me for the time you're here?"
"I understand, nobody likes paying for drive time. How many other things are on your list? My minimum covers travel, tools and insurance, so the best value is giving me several jobs in one visit."

4. "I'll watch a video and do it myself."
"Lots of jobs are DIY friendly. Which part feels risky to you? I can do just the tricky part, like hanging a heavy mirror into studs, and leave the rest to you."

5. “It’s not urgent, maybe next month.”
“No problem. Is anything on the list a safety or water issue, like a loose railing or failing caulk? Those get worse fast. I can do those now and book the rest when you’re ready.”

6. “I’m not comfortable having a stranger in my house.”
“That’s a fair concern. What would make you comfortable? I can send my insurance, reviews and a photo of who’s coming, and text you when I’m on the way.”

7. “Can I pay you next week?”
“I understand. What payment method is easiest for you today? I take cards on my phone, so we can settle up after you’ve checked the work and before I leave. For bigger lists, I take a materials deposit upfront.”

4. Follow up: day 2, day 5, day 12

Most quotes go quiet, not “no”. Keep each message short and useful.

> **Day 2:** “Hi [Name], it’s [Your name] from [Business]. Did the price for your list come through okay? Happy to add or drop anything.”

> **Day 5:** “Hi [Name], I’ll be in your area on [day]. Want me to knock out your list while I’m close by?”

> **Day 12:** “Hi [Name], I’ll close out your quote on Friday. If you’d like to go ahead, or just do the urgent items, reply and I’ll hold a spot.”

Homeowners juggle many small jobs and forget. A friendly reminder is usually welcome, not pushy.

5. Ask for the review and the referral

Ask before you leave, when they’ve just checked the work, and text a direct link to your Google review page.

> “Thanks again, [Name]. If you’re happy with the work, would you leave a quick Google review? I’ll text you the link. And if you think of anything else, start a new list and send it over.”

Realtors and landlords need small repairs every month. One happy realtor can fill your calendar with inspection repair lists.

Three rules that keep you out of trouble

- Know your state’s handyman limit. Don’t take electrical, plumbing or permitted work, and never split a job to stay under the limit.
- Carry liability and business auto cover. A flooded bathroom or a crash on the way can cost more than a year of premiums.
- Agree on the task list and price before you start, and quote add-ons separately.

General education, not legal, tax or insurance advice. Rules and prices vary by state, so check yours.
The full start-up guide for handymen: followthroughguides.com/handyman · Questions: info@followthroughguides.com